

THE EMPEROR WHO WOULD NOT KNEEL

Chapter 9 — “The Gathering Dark”

Format: Traditional right-to-left manga script. Read panels right-to-left, top-to-bottom.

Black-and-white. Heavy ink shadow, cinematic negative space, screentone ash.

Approx. 24 pages.

PAGE 1

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (wide, full-width top — time has passed)

The ruins camp has grown. More souls have arrived — drawn by rumors of a place where the Hollow Men do not hunt. Makeshift shelters lean against broken walls. Small fires burn (giving no warmth, but offering gathering places). The woman in red tends to the boy. BORCHU drills a handful of souls in defensive formations with broken weapons.

No dialogue.

Panel 2 (narrow, center)

ARGHUN sits writing, his ink-stained fingers moving across scraps of salvaged material. Recording. Always recording.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

EGRIS stands at the camp’s edge, watching the horizon. SURO sits nearby, sword across his lap, blindfold facing outward.

No dialogue.

PAGE 2

Panels: 4

Panel 1

SURO, without turning.

SURO: “They look to you more each day.”

Panel 2

EGRIS: “I have not asked them to.”

Panel 3

SURO: “That is why they do.”

Panel 4

EGRIS says nothing.

No dialogue.

PAGE 3

Panels: 3

Panel 1

SURO: "How many now?"

Panel 2

EGRIS: "Forty-three. Arghun counted them this morning."

Panel 3

SURO: "And when it is a hundred? A thousand?"

PAGE 4

Panels: 4

Panel 1

EGRIS: "The same answer I gave him. I am not building an empire."

Panel 2

SURO tilts his head slightly.

SURO: "You are building something. Whether you name it or not."

Panel 3

Before Egris can answer, BORCHU approaches — moving quickly, urgency in his stride.

No dialogue.

Panel 4

BORCHU: "Egris. You need to see this."

PAGE 5

Panels: 2

Panel 1 (large, top)

EGRIS and SURO follow Borchu to the camp's northern edge. A small group of souls has gathered, staring outward into the mist.

No dialogue.

Panel 2 (wide, bottom — reveal)

Beyond the ruins, in the deep Gray: LIGHTS. Not white like Heaven's fire. Not red like Hell's. These are pale, cold, BLUE — dozens of them, moving slowly through the mist like lanterns carried by an unseen procession.

No dialogue.

PAGE 6

Panels: 4

Panel 1

Close on EGRIS's eyes, narrowed, reading the movement.
No dialogue.

Panel 2

SURO, listening.
SURO: "They are not Hollow Men."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "No."

Panel 4

One of the gathered souls — a FARMER with broken hands — speaks, voice shaking.
FARMER: "They've been circling us for hours. Getting closer each time."

PAGE 7**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

BORCHU: "We sent two scouts to see what they were. Neither came back."

Panel 2

The WOMAN IN RED steps forward, still holding the boy's hand.
WOMAN: "We should leave. Move the camp deeper into the ruins."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "And if they follow?"

PAGE 8**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

WOMAN: "Then we keep moving until they stop."

Panel 2

BORCHU shakes his head.
BORCHU: "We cannot keep running. Half the camp can barely walk."

Panel 3

EGRIS continues watching the lights.
No dialogue.

Panel 4

EGRIS: "How many lights?"

PAGE 9**Panels: 3**

Panel 1

FARMER: "Thirty. Maybe more."

Panel 2

BORCHU: "And they move in formation. Disciplined. Like soldiers."

Panel 3

EGRIS's jaw tightens.

No dialogue.

PAGE 10**Panels: 2****Panel 1** (large, top)

SURO stands, hand resting on his sword.

SURO: "Someone sent them."

Panel 2 (wide, bottom)

As if in answer, one of the lights STOPS. Then another. Then all of them — forming a loose perimeter around the camp, just beyond visible range.

No dialogue.

PAGE 11**Panels: 1** (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — the lights stop moving)

The pale blue lights hang in the mist like a constellation fallen to earth. Motionless. Watching. Waiting.

The camp falls silent.

SFX: ...

PAGE 12**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

The boy WHIMPERS. The woman pulls him closer.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

ARGHUN approaches, clutching his satchel.

ARGHUN: "Egris. What are they?"

Panel 3

EGRIS: "I do not know."

Panel 4

ARGHUN, quieter.

ARGHUN: "What do we do?"

PAGE 13

Panels: 3

Panel 1

EGRIS looks back at the gathered souls. Fear in every face. The woman. The boy. The farmers. The broken soldiers. Forty-three souls who came here because they believed this place was safer than the dark.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

EGRIS turns back to the lights.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

EGRIS: "We wait."

PAGE 14

Panels: 4

Panel 1

BORCHU: "For what?"

Panel 2

EGRIS: "To see what they want."

Panel 3

The WOMAN steps forward, anger breaking through her fear.

WOMAN: "And if what they want is us?"

Panel 4

EGRIS, cold and certain.

EGRIS: "Then they will have to take us."

PAGE 15

Panels: 2

Panel 1 (large, top — night falls (the Wastes' version of it))

The gray dims to black. The camp huddles around cold fires. The souls whisper to one another, glancing toward the perimeter where the blue lights still wait.

No dialogue.

Panel 2 (wide, bottom)

EGRIS, SURO, and BORCHU stand watch at the camp's edge, weapons ready.

No dialogue.

PAGE 16

Panels: 3

Panel 1

Hours pass. The lights do not move.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

SURO, quiet.

SURO: "They are testing us."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "Or waiting for orders."

PAGE 17

Panels: 4

Panel 1

Then, without warning, one light begins to MOVE — not toward the camp, but laterally, tracing the perimeter.

SFX (faint): ...ssshhh...

Panel 2

Another light moves. Then another. They circle the camp slowly, tightening the ring.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

BORCHU: "They're closing in."

Panel 4

EGRIS: "Wake everyone. Quietly."

PAGE 18

Panels: 3

Panel 1

The camp stirs. Souls rise, clutching whatever weapons they have — broken stone, rusted blades, lengths of wood. The woman positions herself in front of the boy. Arghun stands with his satchel pressed to his chest, no weapon, only his ink and paper.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

The lights move closer. Now they are visible through the mist — not lanterns. FIGURES carrying the light WITHIN them. Humanoid shapes with pale blue fire burning where their hearts should be.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

SURO's hand tightens on his sword.

SURO: "They are not alive. But they are not Hollow either."

PAGE 19

Panels: 2

Panel 1 (large, top — the figures step into view)

They wear armor — old, battered, from a dozen different eras. Roman. Medieval. Ancient Eastern. The armor is real. The bodies inside it are NOT. They are ECHOES — faint outlines of warriors, held together by duty, purpose, or command that survived death.

No dialogue.

Panel 2 (wide, bottom)

They stop at the edge of the camp, forming a perfect line. Thirty warriors. Silent. Waiting.

No dialogue.

PAGE 20

Panels: 3

Panel 1

For a long moment, neither side moves.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

Then one of the echoes — a ROMAN CENTURION with a cracked breastplate and a gladius in hand — steps forward.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

He does not speak. Instead, he POINTS his sword directly at EGRIS.

No dialogue.

PAGE 21

Panels: 4

Panel 1

BORCHU: "They came for you."

Panel 2

EGRIS: "So it seems."

Panel 3

The CENTURION lowers his sword and plants it in the ground. Then he places one fist over his chest — a salute. A challenge. A declaration.

No dialogue.

Panel 4

Behind him, the other echoes mirror the gesture. Thirty fists over thirty chests.

SFX (layered, synchronized): thump thump thump

PAGE 22

Panels: 3

Panel 1

SURO, low.

SURO: "They are offering you a choice."

Panel 2

EGRIS: "What choice?"

Panel 3

SURO: "Lead them. Or fight them."

PAGE 23

Panels: 2

Panel 1 (large, top)

EGRIS stares at the line of warriors. Thirty disciplined souls, offering him exactly what the Former Rival said he needed — an army. Structure. Order. Strength.

No dialogue.

Panel 2 (wide, bottom)

Behind him, the camp watches. Waiting to see what he will choose.

No dialogue.

PAGE 24

Panels: 1 (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — closing image)

EGRIS, small against the line of thirty armored echoes. The camp behind him. The Wastes stretching endlessly in all directions. His cracked spear in hand.

NARRATION (box, lower corner): An army without a general is a mob. A general without an army is just a man. Egris was neither. And that terrified them all.

— END OF CHAPTER 9 —

SCRIPT NOTES (for artist / letterer)

- **Reading direction:** Right-to-left. Panel 1 sits at top-right of every page.
- **The blue-light warriors** are ECHOES — not alive, not Hollow, not demonic. They are warriors whose sense of duty survived death. Draw them as FAINT — visible but translucent, with the blue light burning in their chests as the only solid thing about them.
- **Page 11 splash (the lights stop)** — keep it minimal. Just the lights in the mist, perfectly still. The stillness is the threat.

- **Page 19 (the warriors revealed)** — each echo should be from a different era/culture. Show visual variety: Roman centurion, medieval knight, samurai, Mongol, etc. They are united by PURPOSE, not origin.
- **The salute (Page 21)** — fist over chest, synchronized. This is NOT submission — it is a warrior's acknowledgment of a leader. The threat is: join us or face us.
- **Tone:** Building dread, slow encirclement, the camp realizing they are being hunted by something organized. This is NOT random — someone sent them. The chapter ends on a cliffhanger choice.